

the message that age is not a deterrent to making it to the Indian team, Lad also believes such instances can't be one-offs.

"There are encouraging signs that domestic cricket is getting its due. Take Saransh, for example. He's 33 and has finally earned recognition after years of consistent performances. It's well deserved. Every now and then, selectors do reward domestic cricketers, and that's a positive sign," Lad says.

"At the same time, it can feel unfair when a player goes straight from a handful of good IPL performances to the India team. The IPL is a fantastic tournament, but the grind of a full first-class season is very different."

Growing up, Lad saw his father, Dinesh Lad, groom several young cricketers, most notably Rohit Sharma, who went on to become stars.

That, Lad feels, happened because domestic performances were never neglected.

"A Ranji Trophy season lasts four to five months, and your preparation starts two or three months before that. You're constantly in that red-ball mindset and rhythm.

You play on different surfaces, in different conditions and against different bowling attacks. That prepares

you for the highest level," Lad says.

"Players who come through a full domestic season are match-ready. They understand how to build an innings, how to bowl long spells and how to adapt to changing conditions. Those are qualities that are difficult to replicate in a shorter format..."

With the focus shifting towards white-ball cricket, the idea of preparing sporting wickets at the domestic level has also changed, which invariably has an impact on the national team.

"If you look at India's recent struggles on turning tracks at home, it's not because our players don't have the skill. We have plenty of quality. The issue is that we don't play enough first-class cricket in those conditions anymore. There is no substitute for that kind of experience," Lad says.

As the players gear up for another gruelling season, the Sooryavanshi appointment sits at the heart of this discussion, not because he isn't deserving, but because it represents a changing philosophy.

For years, leadership in the Duleep Trophy was almost an acknowledgement of years spent performing in first-class cricket.

Sooryavanshi's appointment suggests Indian cricket is increasingly willing to reward potential as much as performance.

East Zone selector Pravanjan Mullick's explanation is straightforward. "We want him to grow, and maybe one day he could even captain India," he says. Many in the domestic circuit, however, aren't convinced.

Their argument isn't against Sooryavanshi. It is about the message such decisions send to players who have spent years grinding through first-class cricket.

The Duleep Trophy has never been short of quality. This season, it also finds itself carrying an unusual burden of proving that it can still shape careers as much as it showcases them.

Duleep Trophy 2025: Top performers



Batters

Rajat Patidar (Central Zone): 382 runs (5 innings, Avg. 76.40)

Yash Rathod (Central Zone): 374 runs (5 innings, Avg. 124.67)

Danish Malewar (Central Zone): 352 runs (5 innings, Avg. 70.40)

Ayush Badoni (North Zone): 307 runs (3 innings, Avg. 153.50)

Ruturaj Gaikwad (West Zone): 200 runs (2 innings; 184 – highest individual score)

Bowlers

Saransh Jain (Central Zone): 16 wickets

Auqib Nabi (North Zone): 12 wickets

Gurjapneet Singh (South Zone): 10 wickets

